

Supporting production can be another avenue—localised units which could be financed with zero or low interest rates. Additionally, these units could utilise technologies like flash-freezing and canning that would serve the dual purpose of supporting food security and driving rural income.

- **Development of Rural MSMEs:** A continued focus on

ist attractions and improving the overall tourist experience through structured skilling would also create an alternative source of sustainable income. New-age experiences including agri-tourism, curated wildlife trails and hikes, in addition to the development of waterfronts can boost local economies. Likewise, developing and reinforcing infrastructure that creates improved social spaces for hospitality,

initiatives for improving access to credit, policy measures that encourage investment could play a big role. Programmes that increase awareness and provide learning to MSMEs on ONDC-based procurement and sales can increase customer access and reduce dependence on third-party marketplaces, reducing the burden from commissions and working capital cycles.

INNOVATION: The heterogeneity of the Indian consumer calls for companies to reinvent their business models and evolve to effectively address customer expectations. Democratised technology and innovations such as AI could create solutions to solve on-ground challenges, which when done even at a small scale can create meaningful stakeholder impact.

And finally, upskilling is critical across all these levers. Industrial training through collaboration between the public and the private sector can prepare the workforce for jobs within the manufacturing space.

Additionally, programmes that aid the development of problem-solving and decision-making capabilities would create transferable skills. In parallel, functional training initiatives that enable on-the-job learning would also help the existing and prospective workforce enhance its productivity.

In addition to vocation-specific skills, basic financial and accounting skills will help with wealth creation and further formalise the economy. **BT**

The author is Chairperson, PwC in India. Views are personal

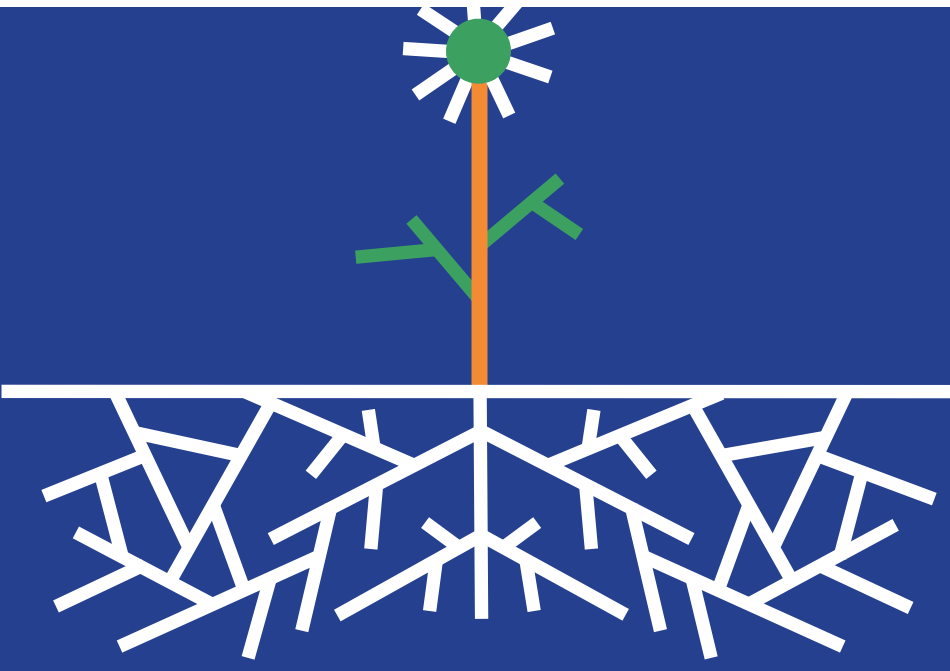


ILLUSTRATION BY ANIRBAN GHOSH

the One District One Product (ODOP) initiative and encouraging traditional craftsmanship through geographical indication tags and leveraging the Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC) can drive economic and social mobility.

- **A 'Master Plan' To Boost Tourism:** Developing new tour-

retail, and leisure can help create revenue models centered on a service culture while also creating ancillary jobs.

IMPROVING MSME RESILIENCY:

Micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs) today employ over 20 million people, and account for about 45% of the country's exports. In addition to existing